Rapa Nui (Easter Island)

A millennium ago, a group of Polynesians settled on a remote island they called Rapa Nui (later renamed Easter Island by Europeans). They erected huge stone monuments (*moai*), using logs to roll them from quarries to ceremonial sites.

When Europeans arrived in 1722, they found a population of only a couple of thousand people, too few to have erected so many *moai*. Thus it was hypothesized that the island's population had formerly been around 15,000—unsustainable on such a small, remote island. A common theory was that the mismanagement of a fragile ecosystem, especially mass deforestation, and warring between tribes, had caused the population decrease.

Recent study of archaeological records of farming methods, however, has suggested that the Rapa Nui people had a stable, thriving population of around 4,000. Research is still ongoing.

The island's population did ultimately collapse, but due to the arrival of traders of enslaved people, bringing diseases such as smallpox. By 1877, only 111 inhabitants of Rapa Nui survived.